transferred to the Anti-Corruption Bureau, the case included even sedition charges for 'horse-trading', which were later dropped.

The plot thickened when Gehlot's parliamentary affairs minister, Shanti Dhariwal, inadvertently admitted in the assembly that the CM's officer on special duty (OSD), Lokesh Sharma, had circulated the tapped recordings to the media. Shekhawat seized upon this admission, filing an FIR against Sharma with Delhi Police in March 2021 for the illegal tapping of phones. The story took another dramatic turn when Sharma turned whistleblower after apparently being denied a ticket to contest the 2023 assembly election. In a series of media releases, he made certain allegations that he claims to have now given to Delhi Police in writing on being summoned on September 25. Talking to INDIA TODAY, Sharma reiterated that Gehlot had allegedly handed him a pen drive containing the audio recordings, instructing him to circulate them to the media, and later destroy it. "I'll hand over whatever evidence I have to Delhi Police whenever they ask for it," he adds.

But the phone tapping saga is just one act in this political theatre. That didn't ipso facto enable Shekhawat to disentangle himself from the 2018 Sanjivani Credit Cooperative Society case, a scheme that allegedly defrauded thousands of investors. Fortuitously for him, though both Shekhawat and his kin had been directors of the society, neither was named as accused in the chargesheet. Now, the SOG, on September 25, has told the Rajasthan High Court that there was no evidence of wrongdoing when they were directors, prompting the court to order no further probe against the Union minister without the trial court's permission.

This has also given Shekhawat an upper hand in the defamation suit he had filed against Gehlot for naming his late mother as an accused before the media. For his part, Gehlot remains defiant, insisting that Shekhawat has not got a clean chit. "The SOG has taken a U-turn because of the change in government," he argues, while choosing not to comment on his former OSD's allegations in the phone-tapping case. As this rivalry enters a new chapter, it shows how in the ever-shifting sands of Rajasthan's political Thar, today's victor may become tomorrow's vanquished. Will there be another twist in the tale? ■

THE SHIFTING SANDS

- **Ashok Gehlot is accused of allegedly orchestrating illegal phone tapping of political rivals, including Union minister Gajendra Shekhawat, in 2020**
- **The former CM could face legal consequences as his former OSD and accused Lokesh Sharma has turned whistleblower in the case registered by Delhi Police in 2021**
- **Meanwhile, the state police wing probing the Sanjivani Credit Cooperative Society case has told the Rajasthan High Court that it has no evidence against Shekhawat**
- **The court has ordered no further probe without the trial court's permission; this has also strengthened Shekhawat's defamation suit against Gehlot**



HIS OWN MAN Engineer Rashid campaigning in Sopore, Sept. 20

As the sun gets milder in Kashmir with the arrival of autumn, the fate of the 346 Independents contesting the 90 seats in the J&K assembly is looking less brighter too.

This is not the first time in the past two decades that such high numbers of Independents are contesting. The 2008 election, soon after the row over land distribution to the Amarnath Shrine Board, saw 468 of them; and the 2014 election as many as 274.

Among the 346 Independents this time are the 34 nominees of the as-yet-unregistered Awami Ittehad Party (AIP), the political outfit floated by former two-time Langate legislator Sheikh Abdul 'Engineer' Rashid. The AIP has also forged an alliance with the Jamaat-e-Islami Jammu and Kashmir, which, despite a ban since 2019, has fielded proxy candidates from 10 constituencies.

However, with the Independents making up 40 per cent of the total 873 candidates, many, including former chief ministers Mehbooba Mufti and Omar Abdullah, are accusing them of contesting in order to split the vote in the Muslim-majority Valley.

So, even as they campaign for votes, the more radical side in the fray is ironically having to counter